Extra Exercises 10 – Reasoning Effort

AI Training for Beginners

Self-study training: use AI/LLMs safely in everyday life

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https://github.com/mgunthner/AI-Training

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Contents

Extra Exercises 10 – Reasoning Effort **1**
Task 1 ★ – Is there a thinking mode? 1
Task 2 ★ – Standard or thinking? 1
Task 3 ★★ – With and without thinking 1
Task 4 ★★ – Checking the calculation yourself 2
Task 5 ★★★ – My thinking rule 2
Suggested solutions 2

Extra Exercises 10 – Reasoning Effort

Cheatsheet: `01_cheatsheets/10_reasoning_effort`

Levels: ★ Getting started · ★★ Everyday · ★★★ Challenge **Rule:** Use only invented or anonymized data. All tasks work with any AI service and on a free plan. Suggested solutions are at the end. Only look once you are finished.

Task 1 ★ – Is there a thinking mode?

Scenario: You don't know whether your service offers a thinking mode.

Task: Search your service for a switch or an option like "think", "thinking" or "Reasoning". Note what it is called, whether you can use it on the free plan and how the vendor describes it. Record the date.

Hint: Some services have no switch or choose the mode automatically. In that case, note exactly that.

Task 2 ★ – Standard or thinking?

Scenario: You have six tasks.

Task: Assign each one: **standard mode** (S) or **thinking mode** (T)? - a) Translate a sentence into Spanish - b) Plan a vacation with budget, travel times and fixed appointments - c) Make an email shorter - d) Solve a logic puzzle with several conditions - e) Collect ten ideas for a weekend - f) Check a weekly schedule to see whether all appointments fit together

Hint: Weighing several conditions at once → thinking mode. Rephrasing and collecting → standard.

Task 3 ★★ – With and without thinking

Scenario: You want to see whether the thinking mode changes anything on a simple logic task.

Task: Give this task once without and once with the thinking mode:

```
Anna, Ben and Carla each have one pet: dog, cat or fish.
Anna does not have the dog. Ben has neither the dog nor the cat.
Who owns which pet?
```

Compare speed, length of the answer and the result.

Hint: With simple tasks, both modes are often enough. That is a valid observation too.

Task 4 ★★ – Checking the calculation yourself

Scenario: The AI is supposed to plan your afternoon. You check whether it calculates correctly.

Task: Ask this question and calculate it yourself:

```
I have 3 hours and 15 minutes. Task A takes 45 minutes,
task B 90 minutes, task C 30 minutes. Between the tasks
I need a 10-minute break each, not before and not after.
Does everything fit in? How much time is left?
```

Does the AI's result match your calculation? If your service shows the thinking steps: are they comprehensible?

Hint: Calculate in minutes.

Task 5 ★★★ – My thinking rule

Scenario: You don't want to reconsider every time when you need the thinking mode.

Task: Write a personal rule following this pattern: "I start in standard mode. If …, I switch on the thinking mode. When …, I additionally verify the result myself." Test it for a week on real tasks and adjust it.

Hint: Remember your limit (topic 15). The thinking mode usually consumes more of it.

Suggested solutions

Task 1: No fixed result. Typical are a switch in the chat, several levels or no selection at all. What matters is that you know what your service offers.

Task 2: S: a, c, e. T: b, d, f. Reasoning: a, c and e are rephrasing or collecting. b, d and f require checking several conditions at once.

Task 3: Solution: Ben has the fish (not the dog, not the cat). Anna has the cat (no dog, the fish is taken). Carla has the dog. Possible observation: both modes deliver the correct result, the thinking mode takes longer and writes more. That matches the rule of thumb: for simple tasks, it isn't worth it.

Task 4: Calculation: 45 + 90 + 30 = 165 minutes of work. Two breaks of 10 minutes each = 20 minutes. Together 185 minutes. Available are 3 hours 15 minutes = 195 minutes. It fits, 10 minutes are left. If the AI deviates, check whether it counted the breaks differently (e.g. three instead of two). Even a thinking mode can miscalculate.

Task 5: Example: “I start in standard mode. If the result is superficial or contradictory, or if several conditions have to fit together, I switch on the thinking mode. For numbers, dates and legal matters, I always verify the result myself.”

Next: Cheatsheet 11 (the AI’s tools), Test B (`03_tests/test_B_good_results`)

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